

College Enrollment and Employment Among Young Adults

Faisal Mulla

September 2026

Introduction

This project looks at the relationship between college enrollment and employment among young adults in the United States. I use the October 2024 Current Population Survey (CPS) School Enrollment Supplement and focus on adults ages 18–24. I look at two main outcomes: whether someone is employed and, if they are working, how many hours they usually work each week.

Data and Methods

I limit the sample to adults ages 18–24 and remove those who are still enrolled in high school. This leaves 7,319 people in the main sample. I first compare employment rates between young adults who are enrolled in college and those who are not. I then run weighted linear probability models and add controls for age and demographic characteristics. I also look at usual weekly work hours among people who are employed. I use CPS person weights and heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in the regressions.

Results

College-enrolled young adults have lower employment rates across ages 18–24. In the first regression, the employment rate for young adults enrolled in college is 26.2 percentage points lower than for those who are not enrolled. After adding age and demographic controls, the difference falls to 20.5 percentage points.

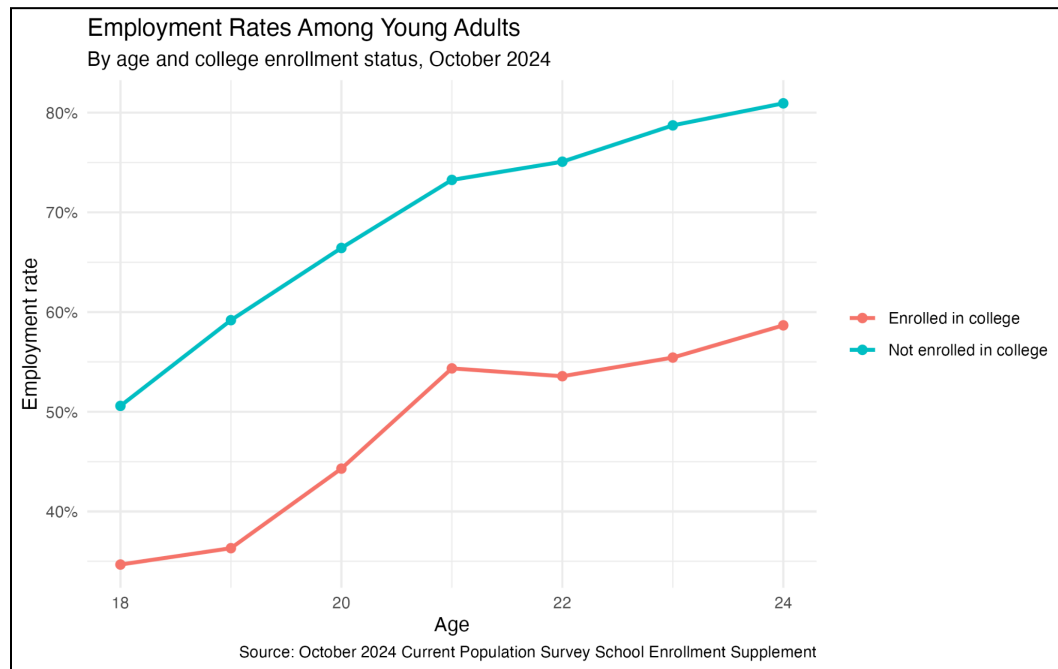
Table 1. College Enrollment, Employment, and Work Hours

	Employment	Employment	Employment	Weekly Hours	Weekly Hours
	Raw	Age controls	Demographic controls	Raw	Demographic controls
College enrolled	-0.262*** (0.013)	-0.210*** (0.014)	-0.205*** (0.014)	-13.591*** (0.415)	-11.731*** (0.434)
Observations	7,319	7,319	7,319	4,260	4,260

*Notes: Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses. All specifications use CPS person weights. Age controls include age indicators. Demographic controls include age, sex, Hispanic ethnicity, and race. Weekly-hours models are restricted to employed respondents with valid work hours. *** $p < 0.001$.*

Among people who are employed, college students also work fewer hours. College-enrolled workers average 23.5 hours per week, compared with 37.1 hours for workers who are not enrolled. After adding age and demographic controls, the difference is 11.7 hours per week.

Figure 1. Employment Rates by Age and College Enrollment Status



Conclusion

The results show that college-enrolled young adults are less likely to work and tend to work fewer hours when they do have a job. These differences remain fairly large after accounting for age and basic demographic characteristics.

There are limits to what I can conclude from this analysis. The data only provide a snapshot of young adults in October 2024, and college enrollment is not randomly assigned. There may be other differences between college students and non-students that I do not observe in the CPS. Because of this, I treat the results as descriptive and do not interpret them as the causal effect of going to college.